



THE RUN WAY: Viveik Oberoi (left) and Zayed Khan in *Mission Istanbul*

more acceptable to audiences," he laughs. This may be why Salman Khan has returned to action in the Boney Kapoor-produced *Wanted: Dead or Alive*, for which he says the actor is training hard. "He has stopped drinking and lost weight. He cycles to work every day," says Kapoor. Aamir Khan, too, is bulking up with celebrity trainer Satyajit Chaurasia for the remake of *Ghajini*.

Shah attributes the race for action to improved safety standards and the ability of Bollywood producers to pay top dollar for the best talent. Guns and gore have been replaced by choreographed violence to appeal to audiences who are weaned on sophisticated video games and Hollywood DVDs. With the demographics moving towards a younger audience, everyone wants sleeker, more believable action. It also has to do with the state of mind of Bollywood's cre-

MISSION ISTANBUL

ACTION STATIONS Rs 6 crore was spent on stunts ranging from a car chase to rappelling off a 102-storey building and leaping off a burning building onto a helicopter.

FIGHT MASTER The young team of Ejaz Gulab and Javed Karim, former assistants of action coordinator Abbas Ali Moghul.

BUDGET Rs 25 cr

ators. As Behl, one of Bachchan's closest buddies, says, "I was working on something else but when I became a father two years ago, I told Abhishek that I wanted my son to know that his dad and his *chacha* (Abhishek) had done something special for him."

For others, it's just the need to do something "classier". As Taurani, whose *Race* has car sequences that were shot in Dubai, with two car rallyists imported from Australia, says, 35 per cent of his film budget was spent on action, but it was worth it to get to a younger audience. Action scenes will also be the centerpiece of *Jodhaa-Akbar*, billed as a classic romance. Twenty per cent of the film's Rs 40-crore budget went towards building up the two gigantic battle scenes of

Panipat and Mankot. Director Ashutosh Gowariker went to the spot of the two battles, and re-created them at Sambar over two months. It was a monumental logistical exercise which involved a crowd

of 5,000 every day. The wake-up call was at 2 a.m. and the first shot at 11 a.m. "Everyone had to go through four departments—uniform, armour, weapons and then the animal handlers," says the director. The armour was designed by Neeta Lulla and crafted in Jodhpur, while the weapons were made by production designer Nitin Desai. The result: two epic battles and a spectacular sword-fight between leads Hrithik Roshan and Aishwarya Rai—the latter had already trained in riding and sword-fighting in the straight-to-video action adventure, *The Last Legion*, where she played the warrior-protector Mira.

Clearly, it's difficult to separate even 16th-century boys (and indeed girls) from their toys. ■